

END OF AN ERA

Rahul Chaudhari's **departure from the Pro Kabaddi League** marks a significant shift, with franchises now prioritising performance and potential over star power, as the latest auction showed.

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If you're an Indian kabaddi fan, there's likely a special place in your heart for Rahul Chaudhari. As one of the sport's original superstars, Chaudhari became the face of the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) and, by extension, the sport in India during a time when fans were searching for the next big name to follow the legacies of veterans like Anup Kumar and Rakesh Kumar.

Long before players like Pawan Sehrawat and foreign stars like Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh brought their own patented brand of effortless confidence to the mat, Chaudhari was the showman who cast a spell on arenas and audiences alike.

His prime years with the Telugu Titans saw him imperiously build a loyal fan-base, and his subsequent moves to Tamil Thalaivas, Puneri Paltan, and later Jaipur Pink Panthers, with whom he won the league in 2022, only added credence to a storied career.

The raider from Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh, has featured in every PKL edition so far. However, a sharp decline in his consistency led to no takers ahead of the 11th edition. In response, Chaudhari announced he would step back from his PKL career, though he remains available to represent his state and country.

Chaudhari going unsold was anticipated by pundits and fans alike, who had been dreading this eventuality for a while. He is part of a generation of players who have been fading from the upper

tiers of performance metrics for some seasons now — whether it's Chaudhari, all-rounders like Deepak Niwas Hooda (former India captain) and Nitin Tomar, or defenders like Surender Nada and Vishal Bhardwaj. Gone are the days when legacy and celebrity guaranteed space under the spotlight. The message was clear — perform or perish.

Reality checks all around

That explains why Sachin Tanwar, a hardworking and under-the-radar raider, became the top buy of the auction, fetching ₹2.15 crore from the Tamil Thalaivas. It also explains why emerging players like Jai Bhagwan (Bengaluru Bulls, ₹63 lakh), V Ajith Kumar (Puneri Paltan, ₹66 lakh), and Sunil Malik (U Mumba, ₹1.015 crore) attracted significant backing and bidding wars.